

Effective Assessment Practices

Plain words. Everyday classrooms. Real Ghanaian schools.

A workshop handbook for Senior High School teachers. Every technical term from the **Teacher Assessment Manual and Toolkit** explained twice: once in plain English, and once as a picture from a classroom like yours.

KATON 2026

Built on the Teacher Assessment Manual and Toolkit
(NaCCA), Ministry of Education, Republic of Ghana.

National Council for Curriculum and Assessment

What is in this handbook

This handbook follows the order of the workshop. It is yours to keep, write on and share. When a term confuses you later in the term, find it here.

	Workshop Objectives	What you should be able to do by the end
1	The Soup and the Meal	The one picture that explains formative and summative assessment
2	AfL, AaL and AoL	The three acronyms, untangled
3	The Three Main Purposes	Before, during and after teaching
4	Ghana's Policy Landscape	The actors, the frameworks, and the 70/30 split
5	The Seven Pillars	What holds a good assessment up
6	Depth of Knowledge	The staircase of thinking
7	Strategies in Action	How to choose one, and four that work
8	Designing a Task & Rubric	Your workshop guide the six steps
9	Common Challenges	The real constraints, and practical answers
10	The Jargon Buster	Every technical term, in plain words
11	Phrases We Get Wrong	Common misreadings, corrected
12	The One-Page Summary	Pin this above your desk

1 The Soup and the Meal

If you remember one picture from this workshop, remember this one

The whole idea of assessment lives in one everyday Ghanaian scene. Think of a woman cooking soup for her family.



Tasting the soup formative assessment

She tastes while the soup is still on the fire. No salt? She adds some. Too much pepper? She adds water. She has not failed the soup she has improved it *before* anyone sits down to eat. That is assessment **for** learning, and it saves the meal.



Serving the meal summative assessment

The cooking is finished. This is the meal as it is. No amount of tasting will help now. You serve it, the family eats, and the meal is judged as served. That is assessment **of** learning end of term, WASSCE, certification.

The question to ask yourself: *does anybody here wait until the food is on the table before they first taste it? Of course not. So why do we wait until the end-of-term exam to find out what our learners misunderstood when it is too late to fix it?*

One more thing worth noticing: the cook who tastes is not being nosy or wasting time. Tasting is not an interruption to cooking tasting **is** cooking.

2 AfL, AaL and AoL The Three Acronyms, Untangled

These three cause the most confusion. Here they are side by side.

Acronym	Full name	Who is doing the work	In one plain sentence
AfL	Assessment for Learning	The TEACHER	I check as we go, so I can teach better.
AaL	Assessment as Learning	The LEARNER	The student checks themselves, so they learn better.
AoL	Assessment of Learning	The SYSTEM and teacher	A final summary of what has been achieved.

AfL and AaL together make up FORMATIVE assessment. AoL is SUMMATIVE assessment.

A simple test to use in your own practice: ask, who is going to change what they do as a result of this information? If the answer is the **teacher**, it is AfL. If it is the **learner**, it is AaL. If nobody changes anything and it simply gets recorded, it is AoL.

AaL is the one we forget. We tell learners their marks, but we rarely teach them to check themselves. That skill is what carries them into university and into work and it is the heart of Assessment as Learning.

Formative vs Summative side by side

	FORMATIVE (the tasting)		SUMMATIVE (the serving)	
When	During teaching the lesson	before, during and after	After teaching programme	end of unit, term, year or programme
Purpose	To IMPROVE learning while there is still time		To PROVE and record overall achievement	
Who uses it	Teacher and learner		School, WAEC and other external bodies	
What it sounds like	I see where you got stuck this way	let us try it	This is your final grade for the term	
Examples	Questions, exit cards, class exercises, observation, peer assessment, drafts		End-of-term exam, WASSCE, projects, portfolios, practicals	

The golden rule most teachers miss

Summative results can be used **formatively**, and formative work can count **summatively**. The label describes the *purpose* the information is put to not the paper itself.

- **Using summative for formative:** mark the end-of-term paper, but instead of only recording scores, hand the scripts back, put learners in groups to find the answers they missed, and re-teach the two topics the whole class failed. That exam just became a teaching tool.
- **Using formative for summative:** the class exercises and the group project you grade against a clear rubric become part of the 30% school-based assessment. Your everyday work is already counting.

Why this matters to you: the same piece of work can do two jobs. You are not being asked to double your marking you are being asked to use the information twice.

3 The Three Main Purposes

Before, during and after teaching and what each one is for

BEFORE you teach Diagnostic assessment

Checking what learners already know and can do **before** you start teaching, so you know where to begin. It is checking your pantry before you cook: have you got the rice? The oil? Is the yam already boiled? Only then do you decide what to cook.

In practice: a five-minute pre-test or entry ticket at the start of a new topic. Ask one question on Monday about the topic you teach on Wednesday and discover that half the class never understood last term's foundation topic. Tools: pre-tests, entry tickets, K-W-L charts, concept maps, short interviews, a simple show of hands.

WHILE you teach Formative assessment

Checking learning while teaching is still going on, so you can fix things before it is too late. Used formally and informally to gather information about learners and their learning needs, so that teachers can modify or improve teaching and learning. The key word is **improve** not **prove**.

In practice: questions, observation, class exercises, draft work, peer and self assessment, exit cards, Think-Pair-Share, concept maps, projects, reflection journals, impromptu quizzes, checklists and rubrics.

AT THE END Summative assessment

A formal, planned check at the end to sum up overall achievement for selection, certification and placement. The cooking is finished; this is the meal as it is. Summative assessment is not the enemy. It has a real and necessary job. The point is only that summative *alone* is a poor diet: if you only ever serve meals and never taste, you will keep serving the same mistakes.

Examples: class tests, end-of-term and end-of-year examinations, Test of Practical, term papers, projects, portfolios, performance and practical assessment, research reports.

Two more forms worth knowing

Differentiated assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Using different ways of assessing so that every learner, whatever their level or need, has a fair chance to show what they can do. **You adapt the route, never the destination.**

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You have a very strong learner and a learner who is struggling. Both must show they understand photosynthesis that is the learning outcome and it does not change. One writes the essay, the other draws and labels the diagram and explains it orally. Both have proven the same outcome. Not easier work for the weaker child, but a different door into the same room.

The six levers: varied formats flexible deadlines varying task difficulty accommodations individualised feedback learner involvement.

Performance-based, practical and authentic assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners **actually do** something real – not just write about it. Authentic – simply means: it looks like real life.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You do not ask them to describe a titration on paper – they stand at the bench and titrate. You do not ask them to list the parts of a machine – they dismantle and reassemble it. Examples: experiments, exhibitions and STEM fairs, fieldwork reports, projects, drama performances, debate, simulation, oral and aural assessment.

e-Assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Using information technology and digital tools to assess learning. It can be used for both formative and summative purposes.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

It does not need a computer lab. A class WhatsApp group where learners submit a 60-second voice note explaining a concept; a Google Form quiz that marks itself; a Kahoot round at the end of a lesson; photographs of practical work sent for feedback. Where internet is a challenge, WhatsApp, SMS and offline forms still count.

4 Ghana's Assessment Policy Landscape

What you are required to do and who requires it

Teachers often carry out assessment requirements without knowing where they come from or what they are for. This section connects the dots.

Who does what

Body	Full name	What they do	Why you should care
NaCCA	National Council for Curriculum and Assessment	Sets the curriculum and the assessment guidance	This handbook's source manual is theirs
MoE	Ministry of Education	Sets national policy, funds the system	Owns the reform behind the current curriculum
GES	Ghana Education Service	Runs public pre-tertiary schools	Your employer; issues day-to-day directives
WAEC	West African Examinations Council	Runs WASSCE the external 70%	Their verdict sits on top of your 30%
NaSIA	National School Inspectorate Authority	Inspects schools	Inspectors will ask to see your assessment records
NTC	National Teaching Council	Regulates the profession: licensure and CPD	Your licence renewal depends on professional development

The frameworks where the rules come from

Framework	Full name	What it covers
NPLAF	National Pre-tertiary Learning and Assessment Framework	The national master document. Defines the principles and forms of assessment for ALL pre-tertiary levels. Every principle in Section 5 traces back here. Read its inclusivity section (page 32).
SEAF	Secondary Education Assessment Framework	How SHS, SHTS and STEM learners are assessed within and across grade levels. The direct rulebook for your classroom. It proposes the two forms: formative and summative.
SBC	Standards-Based Curriculum	The current SHS curriculum, organised by strands and sub-strands, with learning outcomes expressed as standards. Your assessment must align to these that is where validity comes from in practice.

The 70 / 30 split your marks now have weight

Thirty per cent of a learner's final grade comes from work done in your school and marked by you portfolios, performance and project work, plus end-of-term examinations. **Seventy per cent** comes from WAEC's final examination.

For years, internal marks were treated as a formality at the back of the mark book. That has changed. The internal 30% now sits on a **school-based transcript**, with far greater transparency and quality assurance. Practically: if your school's 30% is not credible, transparent and defensible, the learner is the one who suffers when their transcript is scrutinised and the school is the one that is exposed. Reliable rubrics are no longer good practice. They are protection.

Continuous assessment six obligations

Requirement	What it means	Where teachers commonly slip
Assess against curriculum learning outcomes	Tasks must test the standards in the SBC for your level.	Setting questions on content you taught but which is not in the standards or missing standards you did not teach.
Use a variety of assessment methods	Not just written tests. Projects, portfolios, performance, practicals, observation, oral work.	Relying on class tests alone, then finding the 30% is thin and undefensible.
Record results systematically	Every learner's results kept accurately across the term, with the evidence behind them.	Losing the record book or reconstructing marks at the end of term. This is the most common quality-assurance failure.
Give feedback learners can act on	Results must feed back into teaching and into the learner's next steps not just a mark.	Marking and recording without ever handing work back or re-teaching the gaps.
Accommodate learners with SEN	Extra time, alternative formats and appropriate accommodations, applied fairly.	Treating accommodations as favours rather than requirements and keeping no record of what was provided.
Be transparent and consistent	Learners know the criteria in advance; the same rubric is used across classes.	Two teachers marking the same subject to different standards, which undermines the whole transcript.

The self-test

If an inspector asked you to justify one learner's 30% mark today, could you show the work, the rubric and the date? If not, the record needs attention and that is a fixable problem, not a character flaw. One folder per class, one mark book, date everything, keep the rubric with the task. That is the whole system.

5 The Seven Pillars of Effective Assessment

Section 2 of the manual. Think of them as seven pillars holding up a roof – remove one and the building leans.

You will not get all seven perfect every week. But when an assessment disappoints you, come back to this list – the answer is almost always hiding in one of the seven.

1 Validity – measuring the right thing

PLAIN ENGLISH

Are you actually measuring the thing you say you are measuring? A valid assessment measures the important learning outcomes of the curriculum – not just whatever was easiest to set.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A trader uses a weighing scale to sell yam. If she used that scale to measure the **length** of the yam, the reading would be worthless – not because the scale is broken, but because it is measuring the wrong thing. Now think of your last class test. Your learning outcome said learners should **analyse** data. But every question asked them to **recall** a definition. Your test was neat. It was well marked. It was simply measuring the wrong thing.

The quick check: does this question actually test the skill I said I was teaching? **The fix:** build a table of specification – a grid mapping each question to a topic and a thinking level.

2 Reliability – the same result every time

PLAIN ENGLISH

Do you get the same result every time, whoever is doing the marking? Reliable results are dependable enough to make decisions with.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A market scale that gives the same weight for the same pile of tomatoes – on Monday or Saturday, whoever is standing at the stall. Now imagine the scale was generous on Monday and harsh on Saturday. Nobody would trust that market again. If this term's 30 marks in your subject are generously given and next term's are harsh, learners are being ranked against a ruler that keeps changing length.

The manual is blunt about this: the *connoisseur* approach – I know it when I see it but I cannot put it into words – is not acceptable. **The fix:** clear outcomes, a colleague reviewing your marking, more than one method for the same outcome, marking schemes with weightings, and rubrics given out *before* the task.

3 Fairness and ethics – an equitable chance

PLAIN ENGLISH

Giving learners an equitable opportunity to demonstrate what they know and can do, taking into account their ability, learning styles, gender and Special Educational Needs. It also means never assessing what you have not taught.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A test question asks learners to explain the rules of cricket. A learner from a village that has never played – or seen – cricket cannot answer, and fails. That question did not measure physics. It measured cricket. Now swap it for the physics of a loaded trotter braking at a junction, and every learner in the room has something to think with. Same physics. Same difficulty. Fair.

Red flags: culturally biased content – unfamiliar words and examples – assessing content you never taught – failing to give SEN learners extra time or alternative formats.

4 Transparency no secret exams

PLAIN ENGLISH

Making the assessment process and criteria clear and understandable to learners. They should know what is being judged, how it is judged, and what counts as a pass.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Two teachers set the same project. The first says 'do the project, I will mark it' and the learners spend the week guessing. The second hands out the rubric on day one: what is expected, the marks for each part, what a top answer looks like. Both teachers mark with the same rubric. The second class almost always scores higher not because they worked harder, but because they knew where to aim.

Transparency also requires: sharing the learning outcomes being assessed telling learners the pass mark sharing results openly with learners and parents or guardians giving learners a route to seek review and redress.

5 Inclusivity fair and accessible to ALL

PLAIN ENGLISH

Creating assessment practices that are fair and accessible to every learner, regardless of gender, disability, poverty, background or learning difference. The framework names three lenses you must apply: **GESI** (Gender Equality and Social Inclusion), **SEL** (Socio-Emotional Learning) and **SEN** (Special Educational Needs).

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A learner with low vision cannot read an ordinary small-print paper but they understand the work perfectly. A learner who is hard of hearing misses the spoken instructions you gave once, quickly, at the front. A learner who is dyslexic knows the science but loses marks to their handwriting. In all three cases we did not measure their learning. We measured their eyes, their ears and their handwriting.

Practical tools: braille oral translation text-to-speech and other assistive technology sign language interpretation extra time alternative formats. **A warning worth giving:** if you are assessing science understanding, decide deliberately whether handwriting and grammar should cost marks.

6 Practicability can you actually do it?

PLAIN ENGLISH

The assessment must be feasible, convenient, efficient and successful with the real resources you have your actual class size, your actual timetable, your actual materials.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You design a wonderful one-hour one-on-one oral assessment for your Government class. It is rigorous. It is valid. It is inclusive. It is also completely impossible with 60 learners and by Thursday it will have collapsed into chaos, you will be three weeks behind, and you will abandon it. The plan failed not because it was bad, but because it was not practicable. A good assessment is one you can still run in week eight.

The three questions: do I have the materials and the security? does this format suit my class size and their level? do I have the time to set it, mark it and give constructive feedback?

7 Assessment utility is it actually useful?

PLAIN ENGLISH

The assessment must give you and the learner information worth having and that information must lead to action.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

You set a class test. You mark it. You enter the scores in the mark book. You file the papers. Term ends. Now ask honestly: did anybody learn anything from that test? If it did not change what you taught next, and did not change what the learner did next, then all that happened was data collection. Utility is the difference between a test that teaches and a test that merely records.

A test to offer yourself: name one thing you changed last term because of an assessment result. A cook who tastes the soup and then does nothing about it has wasted the taste. Assessing without acting is not assessment.

6 Depth of Knowledge The Staircase of Thinking

How DEEP is the thinking? Not how difficult the words look.

The biggest misconception: teachers think a question is DoK 4 because it uses big words or long sentences. It does not. A long question with big vocabulary that asks you to remember something is still DoK 1. A short, simple question that asks you to judge a real situation and defend your judgement can be DoK 3. **DoK is about the thinking, not the vocabulary.**

Level	Name	Plain English	SHS example	Social Studies
DoK 1	Recall / Reproduction	Give back a fact you were taught.	State three causes of climate change.	
DoK 2	Skills and Concepts	Use your knowledge in a familiar routine.	Explain how the greenhouse effect works, using a diagram.	
DoK 3	Strategic Thinking	Reason, justify, plan. There is more than one route to the answer.	A cocoa farmer's yield is falling. Using the data given, diagnose the likely cause and justify your answer.	
DoK 4	Extended Thinking	Investigate over time, combine ideas, produce something original.	Conduct a week-long survey in your community on waste disposal and present recommendations to the school assembly.	

Why it matters for validity: if your learning outcome is at DoK 3 (analyse , evaluate) and your test questions are all at DoK 1 (state , list , define), your assessment is invalid no matter how well it is marked.

A five-minute exercise: take one question from your last test and label it. Most teachers find their whole paper sits at DoK 1 and 2. That is a diagnosis, not a criticism and it is easy to fix with a table of specification.

7 Strategies in Action

Three of the manual's strategies, brought down to earth

The manual lists around thirty assessment strategies in Section 7. Here are three that teachers most often get wrong, or avoid because they look like too much work. Notice the same pattern in all three: **the strategy is not the hard part. Deciding the criteria before you start is.**

Portfolio the learner's own story

PLAIN ENGLISH

A carefully chosen collection of a learner's work across time, showing progress towards the learning outcomes. Usable formatively and, with a clear rubric, summatively.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Two things separate a real portfolio from a pile of papers. First it is **curated** the learner chooses what goes in, and learns by choosing. Second it carries **reflection** beside each piece, a short note: I chose this because and next time I would . Without reflection you have a folder. With it, you have assessment as learning.

Where the manual helps: Appendix C.1 gives worked portfolio exemplars for Science and Mathematics, including the rubric. **Time-saver:** you do not mark every piece you mark the reflections and the final selection, which is where the thinking is visible.

Debate thinking out loud

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners take a position on an issue, argue it with evidence, and respond to the opposing case. You assess the quality of the thinking, not the conclusion.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A Government class debates: Should Ghana raise the minimum wage? Half the room argues for it, half against. What you are assessing: clarity of the argument use of evidence, not just opinion quality of rebuttal do they actually answer the other side? listening respectful disagreement.

The rule that makes it work: give the rubric *before* the debate and give learners research time. A debate sprung on learners with no preparation assesses **confidence, not competence** and it rewards the loudest voices. Offer a written or small-group alternative for learners who cannot perform before a large audience.

Practical and performance doing it for real

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners demonstrate a skill in a real or simulated setting, and you judge the **doing** not just the writing about it. The manual calls this performance-based, practical or authentic assessment.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

The Chemistry learner stands at the bench and titrates. The Technical Skills learner dismantles and reassembles an engine. The Visual Arts learner throws a pot. The Music learner performs. You are watching the skill, not reading about it. And if you have no laboratory, a simulated or improvised setting still counts the manual explicitly allows real or simulated contexts.

The teacher's five jobs, from the manual: design a task requiring real-life application provide resources, guidance and support evaluate against *predetermined* criteria model the skill serve as coach or mentor throughout. **Why the rubric matters most here:** a written script can be re-read; a practical is judged live, once. Without criteria fixed in advance you will mark the confident performer higher than the careful one and that is a reliability failure, not an opinion.

The Six-Phase Assessment Plan

Turning all of this into a plan you can actually follow

Phase	What it is	Why it matters
1. Learning outcome	What should the learner be able to DO?	Everything else flows from this one sentence. If you cannot state it, you cannot assess it.
2. Assessment strategies	HOW will I find out?	Choose the method that matches the outcome not always a test.
3. Tasks or questions	The actual questions learners will meet.	This is where validity is won or lost.
4. Grading criteria or rubrics	What good looks like, at each level.	Decide this BEFORE learners start not while marking at midnight. This is the biggest cause of unreliable marking.
5. Timeline and sequencing	When each assessment happens.	Spread the load so week eight is not a disaster.
6. Feedback and reporting	How learners act on the feedback, and how parents hear.	If there is no planned time for feedback, there will be no feedback only marks.

8 Designing a Task & Rubric Your Workshop Guide

The six steps, so you can do this again without us

This is the guide we used in the workshop. Use it for any assessment you build from now on. It works for a class test, a project, a practical or a portfolio.

Steps 1 and 2 the outcome and the strategy

Step	What to decide	The test to apply
1. Write the learning outcome	ONE sentence. By the end of this, the learner should be able to Use an action verb : explain, calculate, design, evaluate, demonstrate.	Could I show this sentence to someone else and would they know exactly what to teach and assess? If not, it is too vague.
1b. Check the DoK level	Is your verb at the right thinking level? State = DoK 1. Explain = DoK 2. Analyse or justify = DoK 3. Design or evaluate = DoK 4.	Does the thinking level match the standard in the curriculum for this year group?
2. Choose the assessment strategy	Which family? Informal (observation, questioning) Written (test, essay) Performance (project, practical, portfolio, debate).	Could a learner who genuinely has this skill fail this task for a reason that has nothing to do with the skill?
2b. Sanity-check three pillars	Valid (measures the outcome) Reliable (markable the same way twice) Practicable (runnable in week eight with your class size).	If any of the three fails, change the strategy now not after you have built the task.

Do not think about the task for the first ten minutes. Outcome first the task is easy once the outcome is clear, and almost impossible before it is.

Steps 3 and 4 the task and the rubric

Step	What to decide	The test to apply
3. Write the task	Exactly what the learner must do: the instructions you would give them, and what they must produce. One task not a list of five.	Could a learner who has the skill show it here? And would a learner who only memorised definitions be unable to fake it?
3b. Consider your SEN learners	What accommodations would this task need? Extra time, larger print, an oral alternative, or a written alternative to a performance.	Have I decided this in advance rather than improvising on the day and forgetting to record it?
4. Build the rubric	Three bands : Excellent / Good / Developing. Four criteria at most. Each cell says what the work must show to earn that band.	Could a colleague pick this up and mark the same script the same way I would? That is reliability.
4b. Write the learner-facing version	One or two sentences telling learners what excellent looks like. This is the part handed out before the task.	Have I described the WORK, not the learner? Clear argument with evidence not very good student .

Keep the rubric simple. Three bands and four criteria. A simple rubric used consistently beats a detailed one abandoned in week three.

Step 5 the quality checklist

Read your own work against these six questions. Find the ONE problem that is easiest to fix. Fix it. Then stop.

Check	Ask yourself	If it fails
Validity	Does my task actually measure the outcome I wrote or has it drifted into something easier to set?	Change the task, not the outcome.
Reliability	Could a colleague mark this the same way I would, using only my rubric?	Add specificity to the vague rubric cells.
Fairness	Does the task assume experiences or contexts some of my learners have not had?	Re-context it to something familiar the physics of a trotro, not of cricket.
Inclusivity	Who cannot access this task, and what have I put in place for them?	Add an accommodation and write it down.
Transparency	Could I hand this rubric to learners BEFORE the task, and would it help them aim?	Rewrite the wording so a learner can understand it.
Practicability	Can I run this, mark it AND give feedback with my real class size?	Scale it down. A smaller task you complete beats a grand one you abandon.

9 Common Challenges & Practical Solutions

The real constraints not excuses. Every answer here is startable this term without extra budget.

The challenge	What it looks like	What actually works
My class is too large to assess properly.	60 learners, one teacher, no time. Individual oral assessment is impossible.	Do not assess everyone individually. Use methods that scale: whole-class response, exit cards collected at the door, peer assessment with a rubric, group projects with individual accountability. Sample deeply rather than test everyone shallowly.
There is not enough time in the term.	The syllabus is crowded. Assessment feels like an addition on top of teaching.	Assessment is teaching, not an addition. Three minutes of exit cards replaces an hour of re-teaching material the class already knew. Start small – one exit card a week, not a full new system.
Marking already takes my evenings.	Every script marked in full detail, late at night, then filed.	Mark drafts formatively and the final version summatively. Use rubrics so marking is a judgement against criteria, not a rewrite. And remember: feedback needs <i>time for learners to act on it</i> more than it needs length.
I was never trained to design rubrics.	Rubrics feel like something other people know how to do.	You do not have to start from a blank page. The NaCCA manual's Appendix C has worked exemplars and rubrics for portfolios, projects, debates, practicals, questioning and more. Adapt one.
The learners only care about marks.	Learners skip the comments and look straight at the score.	That is learned behaviour, and it is rational marks are what they have always been rewarded for. Change it by giving them <i>time</i> to act on feedback, and by grading a draft formatively. When feedback visibly improves their next mark, they start reading it.
What about learners who will not engage?	Some learners will not speak in a debate or take part in peer assessment.	Offer alternative formats rather than excuses. A written alternative to a debate still assesses the reasoning. And check your own task first often the barrier is the format, not the learner.

10 The Jargon Buster

Every technical term, in plain words, with a picture

Assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Finding out what a learner knows and can do, and how far they have come towards the goal you set.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

It is not only the end-of-term paper. It is the question you asked mid-lesson and the blank faces that answered it. It is the exercise book you marked at 9pm. Every one of those is assessment and every one changed what you did next.

Learning outcome

PLAIN ENGLISH

A clear sentence saying what a learner should be able to **do** by the end of a lesson or unit.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

By the end of this lesson, the learner should be able to balance a simple chemical equation. Not teach chapter 4.

Diagnostic assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Checking what learners already know and can do **before** you start teaching.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Checking the pantry before you cook. A five-minute pre-test or entry ticket at the start of a new topic.

Formative assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Checking learning **while** teaching is still going on, so you can fix things before it is too late.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Tasting the soup while it is still on the fire. Halfway through the mole concept you see blank faces and stop to re-teach with a different example.

Summative assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

A formal, planned check at the end, to sum up overall achievement for certification.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Serving the meal at the table. The cooking is finished; this is the meal as it is.

Differentiated assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Different ways of assessing so every learner has a fair chance to prove the same outcome.

Change the route, not the destination.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Your top learner writes the essay; your struggling learner draws, labels and explains orally. Same outcome proven twice.

Performance / authentic assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners actually **do** it, in a way that looks like real life.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Not describing a titration on paper standing at the bench doing it.

Portfolio

PLAIN ENGLISH

A **curated** collection of a learner's work across time, showing progress.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Not a folder of everything. Chosen pieces, with a reflection where the learner explains why each was chosen and what they improved.

Rubric

PLAIN ENGLISH

A table showing exactly what counts and how many marks each part is worth, at each level.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A recipe card with measurements. Not add enough salt but one teaspoon. Give it out **before** the task, never after.

Marking scheme

PLAIN ENGLISH

The model answer sheet showing where each mark falls.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Your colleague should be able to mark your paper and produce almost the same scores you did.

Table of specification

PLAIN ENGLISH

A planning grid making sure your test covers the content and the thinking levels it is supposed to.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Instead of 20 recall questions because recall is easy to set, the grid forces balance across topics and DoK levels. Your best defence of validity.

Depth of Knowledge (DoK)

PLAIN ENGLISH

How **deep** the thinking is not how hard the question looks. Four levels.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Four steps up a staircase: recall, skills, strategic thinking, extended thinking.

Project-based assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners work on a meaningful, extended task and produce something real.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Not a weekend homework. A term-long task research, plan, produce, present, and be judged on all of it.

Case study

PLAIN ENGLISH

A real or realistic scenario learners must analyse and decide on.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Here are the accounts of a small market business that is failing. As a consultant, what would you advise, and why?

Test of Practical Knowledge (TPK)

PLAIN ENGLISH

A written paper testing your knowledge of **how to do** a practical the theory behind it.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Why you add acid to the burette the way you do; what would happen if you did not; how you would correct a reading.

Questioning

PLAIN ENGLISH

Using questions deliberately to find out what learners understand and to push thinking deeper.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Not only who can tell me ? to the eager boy in the front row. Deliberate wait time, questions directed by name, and follow-ups like why do you say so?

Think-Pair-Share

PLAIN ENGLISH

Think alone, then discuss with a partner, then share with the whole class.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Three minutes of genuine thinking time, so the quiet learners at the back have something to say by the time you ask.

Think-aloud

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners say out loud what is going on in their head as they solve a problem.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

I am reading the question first I will find the mass now I am not sure which formula to use. It exposes the reasoning a written answer hides.

Exit card / exit ticket

PLAIN ENGLISH

A short question at the very end of the lesson, answered on a slip before learners leave.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Write one thing you learned today and one thing you are still confused about. Three minutes, scrap paper, works with 60 learners.

Entry ticket

PLAIN ENGLISH

A short question at the start of a lesson showing what learners already bring.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Free diagnostic assessment, every single day, at no cost.

K-W-L chart

PLAIN ENGLISH

Three columns: what I **K**now, what I **W**ant to know, what I **L**earned.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Before the topic they fill K and W; after the topic they fill L. It makes learning visible and the learner reflective.

Concept map

PLAIN ENGLISH

A diagram showing how ideas are linked together.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Not a mind-map of neat bubbles only the **arrows must be labelled** (causes , is part of , depends on). The labels are where the understanding is.

Graphic organiser

PLAIN ENGLISH

Any visual frame that helps learners arrange their thoughts Venn diagram, flowchart, table.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Comparing two economic systems in a Venn diagram, where the overlap is the interesting part.

Reflection journal

PLAIN ENGLISH

A learner's own written record of their thinking and growth, reviewed over time.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Five minutes at the end of a double period: what did I find hard today? What will I do differently next time?

Peer assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners assess each other's work against given criteria.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Only works if they have the **rubric in hand** and have been trained to be kind and specific. Otherwise it becomes a popularity contest.

Self-assessment

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners judge their own work against the criteria.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Learner marks their own draft against the rubric, then you mark it. Where the two differ is a goldmine of teaching information.

Metacognition

PLAIN ENGLISH

Thinking about your own thinking. Knowing **how** you learn and **where** you are stuck.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

I understand the theory but I keep making arithmetic slips shows metacognition. I just do not get maths does not yet.

Feedback

PLAIN ENGLISH

Information that helps a learner close the gap between where they are and where they need to be.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

The mechanic. A useless mechanic says the car is bad. A good mechanic points at one exact part: this hose is cracked; replace it and the overheating stops. Specific, targeted, actionable. A score is a verdict; feedback is a map.

Constructive feedback

PLAIN ENGLISH

Feedback that points to the next step, not just the fault.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Your introduction is clear, but your conclusion does not answer the question. Rewrite just the last paragraph, and here is how.

Gamification

PLAIN ENGLISH

Using game elements – points, levels, badges, competition – to drive learning and assessment.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A house-based quiz with a points board; a 'level up' chart on the wall where learners move up as they master each outcome.

Simulation

PLAIN ENGLISH

Creating a safe model of a real situation for learners to work through.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A Model United Nations debate; a courtroom role-play in a Government class; a mock business negotiation.

Dramatisation / dramatic monologue

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learning and being assessed through acting it out.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A Literature learner performs a monologue as a character from *Things Fall Apart*; a History class dramatises a historical negotiation.

Displays and exhibitions

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners present their work publicly, for an audience.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

The STEM fair where Robotics learners exhibit robots they dismantled and reassembled, and the school community views them.

Checklist

PLAIN ENGLISH

A simple yes/no list of what should be present.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Does the practical report have: aim, apparatus, method, results, conclusion? Tick, tick, tick. Fast and reliable for skill sequences.

Critiquing

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learners give reasoned judgement on a piece of work, a performance or an argument, with justification.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

The layout works because the eye moves top-to-bottom, but the key is missing.

Fieldwork / field report

PLAIN ENGLISH

Learning out in the real environment, then writing up what was observed and analysed.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

A Biology class visiting a local river or farm, recording species and observations, then writing a structured report.

Learning analytics

PLAIN ENGLISH

Looking at patterns in assessment data to spot trends and act early.

CLASSROOM PICTURE

Your mark book shows 18 out of 45 learners failed the same mole calculation question – one whole-class gap you can now re-teach, instead of 18 private problems.

10b The System: Acronyms and Structures

The letters you see on circulars and in the curriculum

Acronym	Full name	Plain English	Why teachers should care
NaCCA	National Council for Curriculum and Assessment	Sets the curriculum and assessment guidance	This manual comes from them
MoE	Ministry of Education	The ministry running the system	Funds and directs policy
GES	Ghana Education Service	Runs public pre-tertiary schools	Your employer
WAEC	West African Examinations Council	Runs WASSCE, the external exam	Their 70% sits on top of your 30%
NaSIA	National School Inspectorate Authority	Inspects schools	They will look at your assessment records
NTC	National Teaching Council	Regulates the teaching profession	Licensure and continuous professional development
NPLAF	National Pre-tertiary Learning and Assessment Framework	The national master document on assessment	Read its inclusivity section (page 32)
SEAF	Secondary Education Assessment Framework	How SHS learners are assessed across grade levels	The direct rulebook for SHS
SBA	School-Based Assessment	Assessment done in school, by you, and counted	It is the 30%
PLC	Professional Learning Community	Teachers who meet regularly to learn together	Like today, but ongoing
CPD	Continuous Professional Development	Ongoing learning for teachers	Your licence renewal depends on it
SEN	Special Educational Needs	Learners who need specific support	Inclusivity is not optional
GESI	Gender Equality and Social Inclusion	No learner disadvantaged by gender, disability or background	A cross-cutting requirement
SEL	Socio-Emotional Learning	The learner's feelings, attitudes and social skills	It is assessed, not just academic work
DoK	Depth of Knowledge	The four levels of thinking depth	Used in the curriculum's assessment tasks
21st-century skills		Critical thinking, creativity, collaboration, communication	WAEC now tests these

The 70/30 split your marks now have weight

Thirty per cent of a learner's final grade comes from work done in your school and marked by you portfolios, performance and project work, plus end-of-term examinations. **Seventy per cent** comes from WAEC's final examination.

For years, internal marks were treated as a formality at the back of the mark book. That has changed. The internal 30% now sits on a **school-based transcript**, with far greater transparency and quality assurance. Practically: if your school's 30% is not credible, transparent and defensible, the learner is the one who suffers when their transcript is scrutinised and the school is the one that is exposed. Reliable rubrics are no longer good practice. They are protection.

The school-level question worth asking: do all of us teaching the same subject at the same level use the same criteria? Could we produce the evidence if NaSIA asked?

11 Phrases We Get Wrong

Common misreadings, corrected

People say	But the manual means
Formative assessment is just class exercises.	Formative assessment is a purpose any assessment used to <i>improve</i> learning, including a homework, a question or a conversation. The tool matters less than the use.
Continuous assessment means plenty of tests.	It means a variety of evidence over time projects, portfolios, observations, performance not just a bigger pile of papers.
I differentiate, so I give the weak ones easier work.	Differentiation changes the route, not the destination. The learning outcome stays; the support and format change.
The exam is over, so I just record the marks.	The manual explicitly says to use summative results formatively hand the paper back, let them discuss the errors, and re-teach the gaps.
I marked it and gave it back.	Feedback without time to act on it is decoration. Leave space in the next lesson for learners to use it.
Feedback means saying good work .	It means telling the learner exactly where the gap is and what the next step is.
Setting multiple-choice questions is easy.	It is the most difficult item type to write well. Distractors must reflect real misconceptions , not random wrong answers.
Assessment is extra work on top of teaching.	Assessment is the thing that tells you whether your teaching landed. Done well, it reduces your work because you stop guessing what to re-teach.

Three things to try on Monday

- **An exit card.** Last three minutes: write one thing you learned today and one thing you are still confused about. Collect at the door. You now know exactly where to start next lesson. Three minutes, scrap paper, works with 60 learners.
- **An entry ticket.** First three minutes: one question that shows what they already bring. Free diagnostic assessment, every single day.
- **A Think-Pair-Share.** Think alone, discuss with a partner, then share with the class. Three minutes of genuine thinking time means the quiet learners at the back have something to say when you ask.

Pick one. Not all three. Spoken commitment increases follow-through tell the person next to you which one you chose.

12 The One-Page Summary

Pin this above your desk

Assessment is not the exam at the end.

It is the nervous system of your teaching.

Assessment FOR learning the teacher listens and adjusts.

Assessment AS learning the learner reflects and adjusts.

Assessment OF learning the system records and certifies.

BEFORE you teach, you check what they bring (diagnostic)

WHILE you teach, you check and adjust (formative) *you taste the soup*

AT THE END, you summarise (summative) *you serve the meal*

ALL THE WAY THROUGH, you make it valid, reliable, fair, transparent,
inclusive, practicable and useful.

And the two sentences that carry it all:

The learner must know what good looks like and must be given time to get there.

Where to go for more

- **The Teacher Assessment Manual and Toolkit Handbook for Teachers**, NaCCA, Ministry of Education, Republic of Ghana. Free on the NaCCA curriculum resources portal (curriculumresources.edu.gh). **Appendix C** contains ready-made exemplars and rubrics for almost every strategy named in this handbook portfolios, projects, debates, questioning, practicals, gamification and more.
- **Appendix A** lists the assessment strategies embedded in each subject's curriculum, including strategies for learners with Special Educational Needs and the Depth of Knowledge levels.
- **Appendix B** is a toolkit covering learners with SEN, identifying gifted and talented learners, internal assessment practices and critical thinking skills.

Compiled for the KATON 2026 workshop on Effective Assessment Practices. Definitions and frameworks follow the NaCCA Teacher Assessment Manual and Toolkit; the plain-English explanations, classroom pictures and matter-of-fact advice were added for teachers, by teachers. Share it freely.